



THE PEOPLE OF BANGLADESH—which got its independence in 1971— BENGALIS

and those of the Indian province of West Bengal speak the same language, share a rich literary heritage, and come from the same ethnic stock. However,

PEOPLE OF THE GANGES RIVER DELTA

Calcutta

Calcutta—or Kolkata, as it has been renamed—is one of India's main cities and home to 14 million people. The city's resources have been stretched to their limits. The air is polluted with traffic fumes and the water contaminated with disease, especially during the flooding of the monsoon season.



Garlands of flowers for Hindu worship on sale at Howrah flower market.



HINDU WORSHIP

Having ritually bathed in the Ganges River these women offer gifts of flowers, incense, and holy water to the god Shiva. Shiva represents destruction and is identified with the Ganges, whose waters bring both prosperity and death. There are many gods in the Hindu religion, each representing a different aspect of the one ultimate God, Brahman, and the workings of the universe.

GETTING AROUND

Calcutta has buses, trams, taxis, a subway system, and car, cycle, and human-drawn rickshaws. The latter come into their own during the floods when water often reaches waist height.



ON THE STREETS

Many homeless people live on the streets of Calcutta. This small shelter is home to a family of seven. Their father can only afford to send one of his five children to school.

